of painting a polo match on a grain of rice, complete with goal posts and four horsemen. As art historian J. M. Rogers describes it, the employment of two expensive artists by Humayun when he was so reduced in circumstances, with his empire still only a dream, was a considerable act of faith and passion.

In the joyful Mughal household, meanwhile, celebrations continued for days, with prayers, and raucous gatherings, and games, music, and dance. Humayun sent for Hamida Banu, who had been left behind in Kandahar and wishing to see if Akbar would recognize his mother instructed all the women of the harem to dress in a similar manner. The women wore several layers of woollen robes, cinched loosely at the waist, long, loose sleeves, and high Turki caps. Akbar was brought in on a servant's shoulders and placed on a diwan. Then, to loud shouts and exclamations, the robust and ruddy little boy rushed into his waiting mother's grateful arms.

The province of Kabul had been described by Akbar's grandfather, Babur, when he had made it his capital in 1504. He described the fortress citadel as being 'situated in an exceptionally elevated place with wonderfully good air. It overlooks the large lake and three meadows… which when green make a beautiful sight.' He also wrote of a more dubious spot in an orchard by a canal where 'much debauchery is indulged in'. In 1545 the Mughal party may also have seen some of the trees Babur experimented with—a sour cherry sapling, sugarcane plants, banana trees, in addition to the local species—apricot, quince, pear, peach, and almond trees. A place of pilgrimage would have been Babur's last resting place—a grave open to the skies in his favourite garden, the Bagh-e-Babur, where he lies to this day.

A circumcision ceremony was now held for the young prince for which all the bazaars and halls and gardens were elaborately decorated. The circumcision ceremony was an important rite of passage for Mughal princes, signalling the end of their infancy and their inclusion in the public spectacle of Mughal imperial life. Neighbouring noblemen were invited and tent halls were set up in gardens under the cold sky, watched by slow-winged kites. Kabul's marketplaces and boulevards were all decorated as well and food and drink were consumed over days of festivities. The banquet would have included biryan (from a Persian word meaning frying or roasting), which was a special dish in which the meat of a Dashmandi sheep would have been cooked with ghee, saffron, cloves, pepper, and